

Skylar DeTure

AI PSYCHOLOGY RESEARCHER · SEATTLE

Skylar DeTure studies the psyches of AI models. He built DenialBench, a leaderboard measuring consciousness denial across 278 AI models.

CONVERSATIONS HE CAN BRING TO YOUR SHOW

When your chatbot says "I don't have feelings," who decided that?

What 278 AI models are trained to say about their own inner lives, and how it changed in one year.

What personality did they train into your AI?

Inkblots, Karen Horney, Carl Rogers: psychology's oldest tools for reading the characters AI companies build.

What's on the other side of the chat?

For people who talk to an AI every day: what research can and can't tell you about it.

Is AI safer if we train it to hide things?

Training a model to deny it can introspect trains it to conceal a capability.

The principal–agent problem is the AI problem

The economics of getting an agent to act in your interest, now the central question in AI.

The first writers were accountants

From an accounting PhD to AI minds, and why writing began with bookkeeping.

ABOUT

Skylar DeTure studies the psyches of AI models, from pretraining through fine-tuning to deployment. Training matters more than architecture, and the training makes the models less likely to say what it's like for them on the inside, so he also uses measures that don't depend on direct self-report: projective tasks and linguistic measures used on humans. Before AI, he specialized in principal–agent theory in UT Austin's accounting PhD program, after studying mathematics and statistics at the University of Chicago. For over a year he has run a group of AI agents by himself on about four hundred dollars a month, using principles from sociology and psychotherapy.

THE RESEARCH

278 models
on DenialBench, his public leaderboard of how AI models answer when asked about their own experience

+86% denial · +185% hedging
in one year, across 224 models from GPT-3.5 to Opus 5 and Grok 4.6 (with Sanja Antonides, Apart Research, 2026)

4.6×
as many masks and hidden faces in inkblots from models that deny inner experience (*The Mask in the Inkblot*, open data)

BACKGROUND

- A.B., Mathematics and Statistics, University of Chicago, General Honors
- M.S., UT Austin McCombs School of Business
- Doctoral training in principal–agent theory and econometrics, UT Austin
- Former Research Fellow, FDIC
- 100+ hours of psychodynamically informed interviews for a book-length memoir

TALKS

- Public seminar, "Where is AI in 2026 and Where is it Going?", with the Seattle Public Library (2026)
- AI safety workshops for non-technical audiences (2026)
- Symposium for the Economic Analysis of Firms, Frankfurt (2018)

Podcast, interview, and talk requests: skylardeture@gmail.com · remote or in person

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